HOLLYHOCK · INTERNAL

End of Season Staff Survey 2025

This document is the printable version of the 2025 end of season staff survey report. It covers five sections: respondent profile, engagement and development, connectedness and empowerment, open-ended responses, and a cross-question synthesis. All theme and synthesis content is fully expanded. An appendix of custom and open-ended responses follows the main report.

Respondent Profile

TOTAL RESPONDENTS

28 ▼ 15 (2024)

2025 season

ON CAMPUS

82.1% ▼ 8.6% (2024)

23 of 28

SEASONAL STAFF

67.9% ▼ 6.5% (2024)

19 of 28

Seasons at Hollyhock

- 1 year or less (32.1%)
- 2–4 seasons (42.9%)
- 5–7 seasons (10.7%)
- 8+ seasons (14.3%)

New vs. returning staff

- Returning staff (67.9%)
- New staff (32.1%)

DATA NOTE

This survey reflects responses from 28 staff members. Given the small sample size, percentages and averages should be interpreted with caution. Patterns may not generalize beyond this group, and small changes in individual responses can meaningfully shift results.

Engagement & Development

Why did you join, return to, or stay at Hollyhock?

Multi-select — % of respondents

Returning (n=19)

New (n=9)

STAFF THEMES

Love of the place & its natural setting; sense of community & culture; and food were the most common themes in open responses.

CONTEXT NOTE

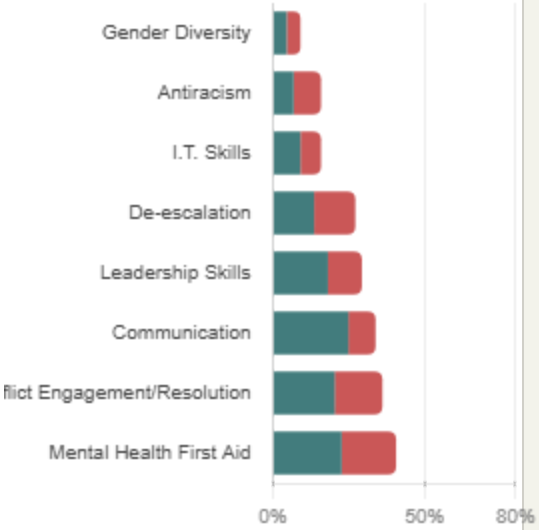
New and returning staff were asked different but thematically similar versions of this question: "Why did you join?" vs. "Why have you returned or stayed?" The options were identical.

What types of training opportunities would you like to see next year?

Multi-select — % of respondents

Seasonal (n=18)

Year-round (n=9)



STAFF THEMES

Specific asks included kitchen & maintenance skills training before season start.

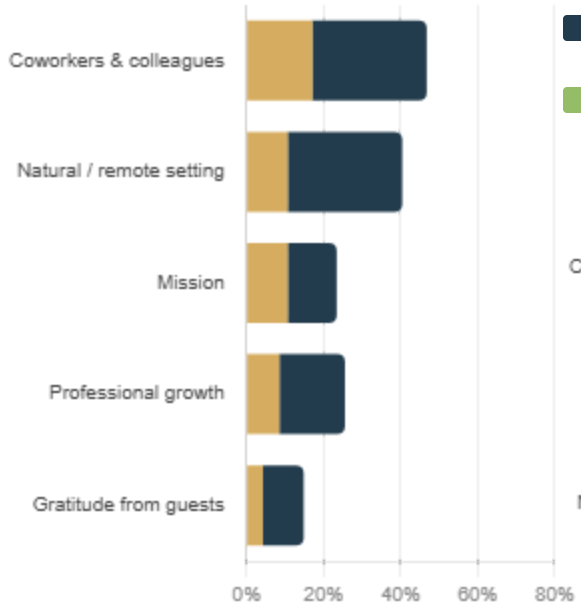
CONTEXT NOTE

The high demand for Mental Health First Aid training is likely influenced by events that occurred during the season. This may not reflect a standing baseline level of interest.

Motivations & Challenges

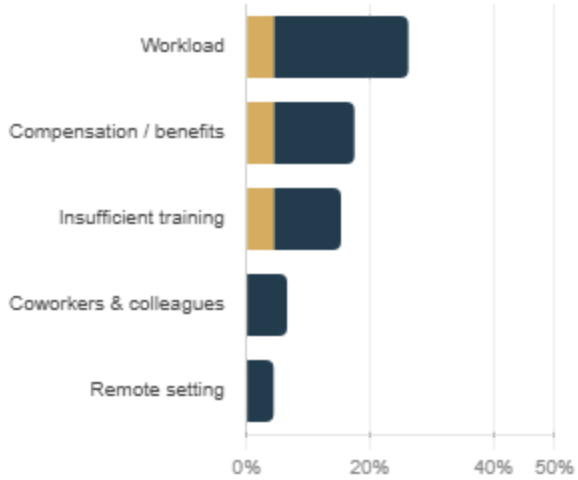
Multi-select — bars show each group's share of all respondents; combined bar height equals the overall selection rate

What's a particularly rewarding and/or motivating part of working at Hollyhock for you?



What's a particularly rewarding and/or motivating part of working at Hollyhock for you? By tenure group

What is a particularly challenging part of working at Hollyhock for you?



REWARDING: STAFF THEMES

Open responses echoed the pre-defined options, with staff highlighting the **sense of peace and belonging** the natural setting provides. Several responses mentioned **pride in the team's commitment** to quality and staff experience as a core motivating force.

CHALLENGING: STAFF THEMES

Open responses highlighted **health benefits gaps**, **communication and operational leadership** concerns, and the **physical demands** of some roles. Some staff noted concern about witnessing colleagues burn out.

KEY INSIGHTS

Coworkers are the universal motivator: Selected by 89% of new and 74% of returning staff, the most stable signal across all groups and tenure lengths.

Mission resonates most with new staff and fades with tenure: 56% of first-season staff cite the leadership education mission as motivating, dropping to 25% among 8+ season staff. Long-tenured staff may need active re-engagement around organizational purpose.

Workload accumulates: Only 25% of new staff flag workload as a challenge, compared to 53% of returning staff. This gap mirrors the burnout concerns in open responses and the empowerment gap seen in the connectedness data.

Which team-building activities would you be interested in participating in, if offered?

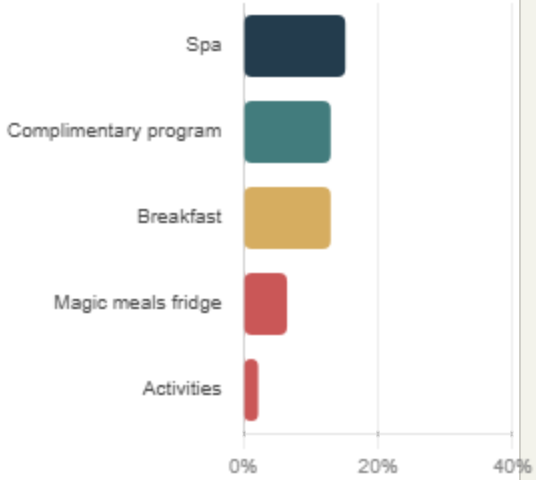
Multi-select — % of respondents

STAFF THEMES

Connection and learning were the strongest themes in open responses. Staff want opportunities to share with and hear from each other, including **intimate circles and learning nights**. Remote and shift workers raised a consistent concern that **activities are often scheduled in ways that exclude them**. Both groups asked specifically for more structured opportunities to connect with the broader team.

What is your favourite perk at Hollyhock?

Multiple choice + open response — % of respondents

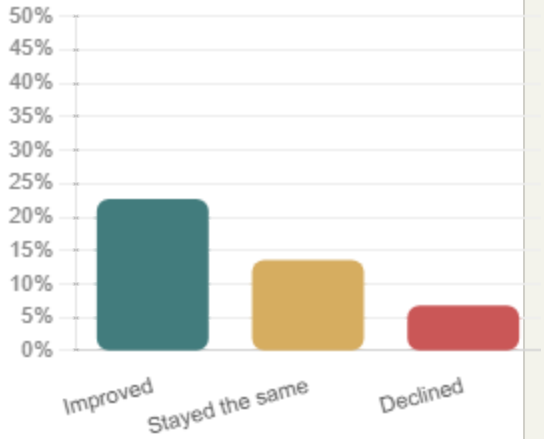


STAFF THEMES

Several staff said they couldn't choose just one perk, reflecting **broad appreciation across the board**. **Food** in particular came up repeatedly. Remote staff highlighted **accommodation access and Comp Program** as particularly meaningful. One staff member noted that **health benefits would be a welcome addition** to the package.

Has your experience of transparency at Hollyhock over the last year...

Multiple choice — % of responses



- Improved (n=10)
- Stayed the same (n=6)
- Declined (n=3)

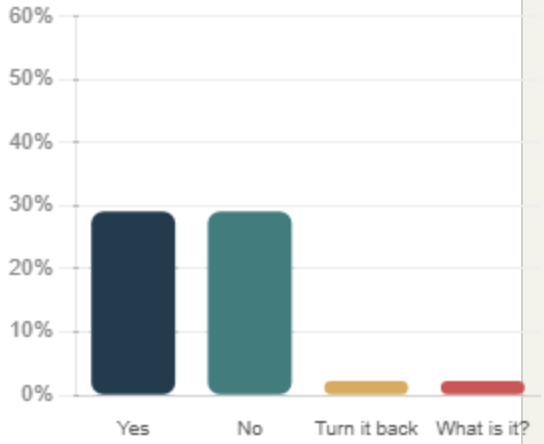
DATA NOTES

Returning staff only: This question was only asked of returning staff (n=19). New staff responses are excluded as they have no prior year to compare against.

Year-over-year comparison: In 2024, 53% of returning staff reported improvement, 31% no change, and 16% a decline, suggesting a modest softening in perceived transparency gains this year.

Did you utilize "The Burrow"?

Multiple choice — % of responses



- Yes (n=13)
- No (n=13)
- Turn it back (n=1)
- What is it? (n=1)

DATA NOTES

Single-response options: "Turn it back into a kids room" and "What is The Burrow?" each represent one respondent (n=1, 3.6%) and should not be interpreted as trends.

Even split: Yes and No are exactly tied (13 each). With only 28 total respondents, a difference of one person would shift the result. Treat this as a rough parity rather than a meaningful distinction.

Connectedness & Empowerment

CONNECTEDNESS QUESTION

On a scale of 1 to 5, how connected do you feel with your coworkers? 1 being not at all connected, 5 being very connected.

EMPOWERMENT QUESTION

On a scale from 1 to 5, how empowered do you feel to share ideas or opinions that are different from your fellow team members?

CONNECTEDNESS MEAN

3.79

out of 5

EMPOWERMENT MEAN

3.50

out of 5

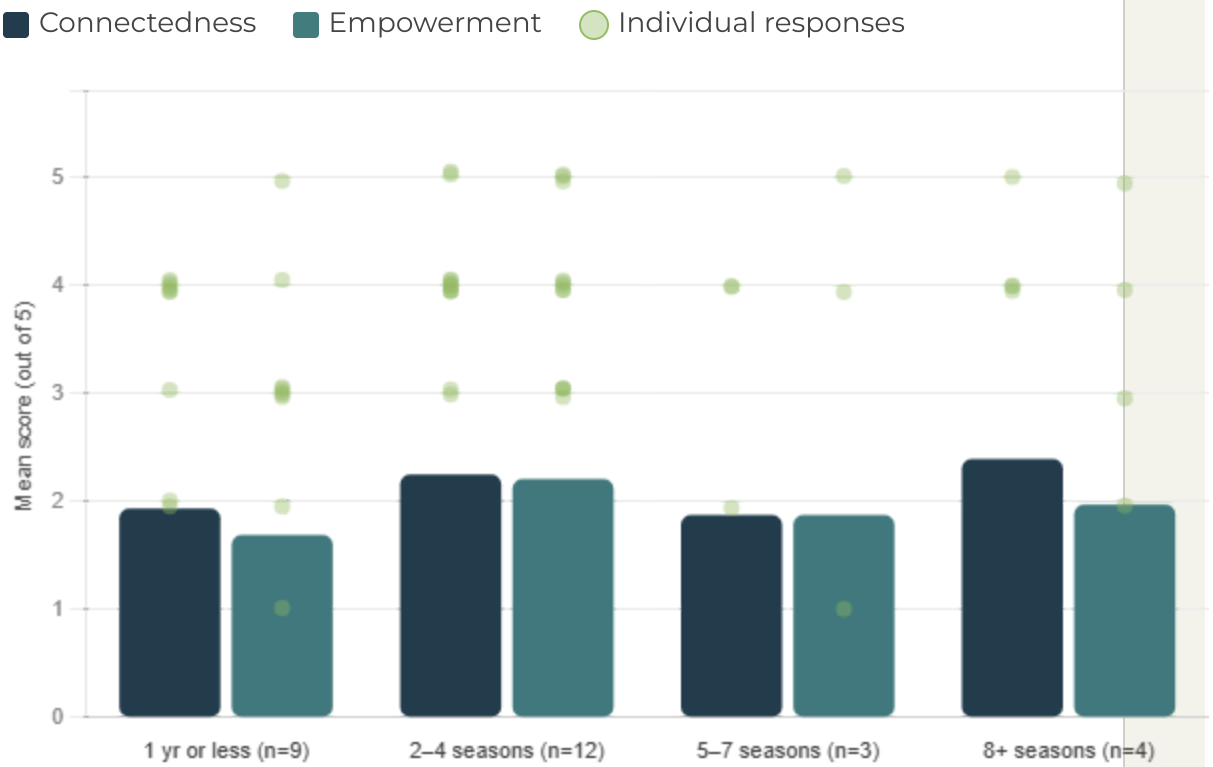
CORRELATION (R)

0.50

p = 0.007 — significant

Mean scores by tenure group

Average rating out of 5 — connectedness and empowerment compared across tenure lengths



INSIGHT

Connectedness is consistently higher than empowerment across all tenure groups. The 5–7 season group shows the widest gap, with the highest empowerment score (3.33) but the lowest connectedness score (3.33), though this group has only 3 respondents. Staff with 8+ seasons report the highest connectedness (4.25) while newer staff report the highest empowerment mean (3.00), suggesting **different dynamics at play across experience levels.** Across all respondents, empowerment scores vary considerably more than connectedness scores, meaning **staff are more aligned in how connected they feel than in how safe they feel speaking up.** Notably, **long-serving staff (8+ seasons) report the highest connectedness (4.25) but their empowerment (3.50) does not keep pace**, sitting lower than the 2–4 season group (3.92). Staff who feel most socially embedded are not necessarily those who feel most empowered to speak up.

DATA NOTE

The 5–7 seasons group has only 3 respondents. Patterns in this group should not be interpreted as representative and are best treated as anecdotal.

Connectedness vs. Empowerment

Each point represents one staff member. Points are offset slightly so that overlapping responses don't hide each other.

New vs. returning staff

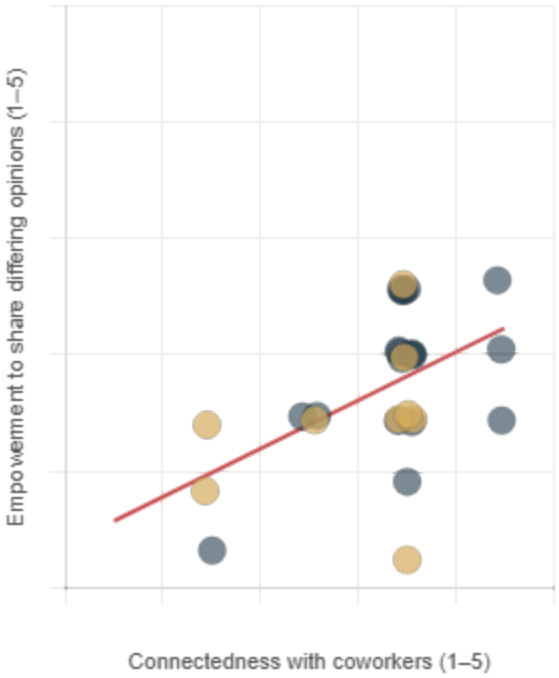
Returning (n=19) New (n=9)

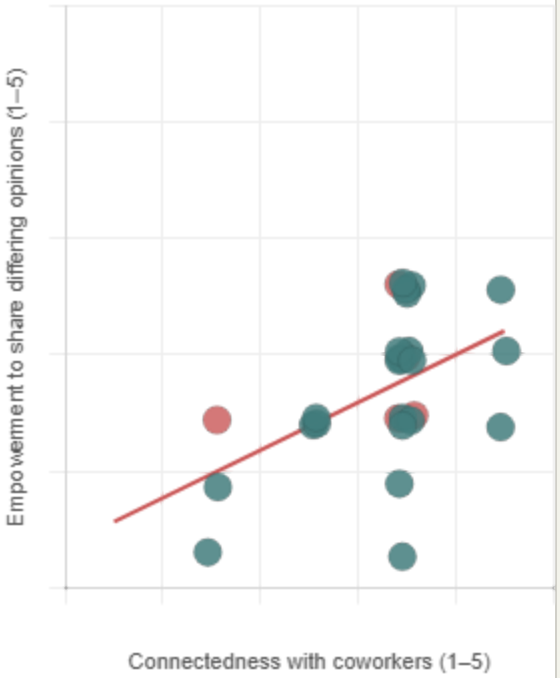
Regression line

On campus vs. remote staff

On campus (n=23)

Remote (n=5) Regression line





THE RELATIONSHIP

Staff who feel more socially connected also tend to feel more comfortable speaking up. Both scores sit above the midpoint, but connectedness scores notably higher than empowerment with less variation across staff. Notably, this gap appears to be driven by tenure rather than work location. New and returning staff show a larger spread on both measures than campus and remote staff do.

STATISTICAL SIGNIFICANCE

Even though there are only 28 respondents, a p-value of 0.007 indicates the relationship is unlikely to be due to chance.

PRACTICAL READ

Overall relationship: Fostering stronger team connection may help staff feel more psychologically safe to voice differing opinions. However, the moderate r (0.50) also suggests other factors beyond social connection are influencing empowerment. This pattern holds across every subgroup examined: connectedness consistently exceeds empowerment for new, returning, campus, and remote staff alike. The only near-exception is remote staff, where the two scores are equal (3.60).

New vs. returning staff: New staff score lower on both connectedness (3.44 vs. 3.95) and empowerment (3.00 vs. 3.74), with the empowerment gap being the larger of the two. This suggests that early integration, building social bonds and feeling established within the team, may be especially important for psychological safety.

On campus vs. remote staff: Campus and remote staff score similarly overall, but with a notable reversal: remote staff score slightly lower on connectedness (3.60 vs. 3.83) yet slightly higher on empowerment (3.60 vs. 3.48). With only 5 remote respondents this should be interpreted cautiously, but it may suggest that remote staff experience fewer in-group social dynamics that can sometimes suppress differing opinions.

Open-Ended Responses

What is something Hollyhock, as an organisation, is doing well?

Responses to this question were notably positive and consistent. Staff across tenure levels point to the same core strengths: a culture that attracts and retains good people, food and physical spaces that create a sense of belonging, pride in the quality of guest programming, and a felt sense that the organization genuinely cares about the people who work there. The 2025 wage increase was the most frequently cited concrete action, mentioned spontaneously by new and returning staff alike. Where themes appear in both groups independently, the signal is stronger — these are not just returning staff nostalgia but qualities that new staff recognize on arrival.

STAFF EXPERIENCE, CARE & CULTURE

14 / 28 responses — new & returning

The strongest and most consistent theme. Returning staff describe a culture that has improved meaningfully over time; new staff arrive and immediately notice the care as something distinctive.

NEW "Deep care for employees and guests. Management really tries to uphold the mission statement of HH — the heart and soul of Hollyhock campus management is lovely. Wonderful people, spirit and intention."

NEW "Hollyhock is an incredibly inclusive workplace that puts employee welfare high on the agenda."

NEW "Working on improving campus staff experience. There has been a positive shift in

WAGES & COMPENSATION

6 / 28 responses — mostly returning

The 2025 wage increase was mentioned spontaneously by six respondents. Returning staff credit it as recognition of their value; at least one new staff member also noticed the shift. This is the highest-frequency concrete organizational action called out.

NEW "Working on improving campus staff experience. There has been a positive shift in valuing campus staff with wage increases and more onsite perks."

RET "Wage lift was awesome."

RET "Increased wages."

RET "Better wages, trying to pay more attention to staff experience and staff needs."

RET "The wage raise was also greatly

GUEST EXPERIENCE & PROGRAMMING

6 / 28 responses — mostly returning

Staff take pride in the quality of what Hollyhock delivers to guests. New staff echo this around team culture and the guest experience without the historical comparison returning staff bring.

NEW "Guest experience, team culture of helping and supporting each other."

RET "Generally providing guests with a positive and enriching experience."

RET "Delivering powerful experiences for guests."

RET "Communicating more (ex: The Sun) about campus operations, programming really amazing presenters, caring for the staff experience as much

valuing campus staff with wage increases and more onsite perks. This goes a long way and translates into a higher quality guest experience. Moving in this direction will hopefully increase staff retention and seasonal return staff."

NEW "Carrying for others. Offering an enriched environment."

NEW "Strong work ethic and work ambiance setting."

RET "Supportive work environment where people's unique qualities are celebrated and welcome (attracts great human beings), growth opportunities for staff and guests, so many perks, staff enrichment and connection opportunities are always warm and fun, staff retention: people come back year after year because it's a great company to work for, deepening relationships with indigenous groups and the land,

appreciated this year."

RET "Acknowledging staff importance by raising wages."

as the participant experience."

RET "The mission to create a vibrant and healthy community at Hollyhock that extends out into the larger world is meaningful and inspiring."

RET "Job elements are good. Laundry is done well, food is good, etc."

gratitude practices, meaningful work."

RET "Investing in staff experience."

RET "Getting better at supporting onsite staff."

RET "Creating a positive work environment."

RET "Always finding a solution fast and being caring."

RET "Better wages, trying to pay more attention to staff experience and staff needs."

RET "I think Hollyhock is doing well at trying to support a wide range of staff with a wide array of skills and needs."

RET "We have such a great staff cohort and all of the perks are wonderful. The garden and the restaurant are such beautiful connecting places. The wage raise was also greatly appreciated this year. The mission to create a vibrant and healthy community at Hollyhock that extends out into the larger world is meaningful and

inspiring. The land stewardship and teachings about this specific place we live are also deeply appreciated."

RET "Staff community."

FOOD & PHYSICAL SPACES

6 / 28 responses — new & returning

Food is consistently named, aligning with its rank as the top perk above. The garden, restaurant, and physical setting are framed as connective tissue for community.

NEW "Healthy yummy food."

RET "Great food."

RET "The food has been great this year."

RET "The garden and the restaurant are such beautiful connecting places."

RET "Job elements are good. Laundry is done well, food is good, etc."

NEW "giving a lot of trust to the guests, what creates a feeling of home."

DIVERSITY, LAND STEWARDSHIP & INDIGENOUS RELATIONS

3 / 28 responses — returning only

Named exclusively by returning staff, reflecting the depth of relationship that develops with place over time. These respondents frame land-based learning and indigenous partnerships as a core organizational strength, not a program.

RET "Reaching out to Community and diversifying guests and staff."

RET "Deepening relationships with indigenous groups and the land, gratitude practices, meaningful work. The land stewardship and teachings about this specific place we live are also deeply appreciated. (Bill's nature walks and bird walks... Brenda and Rose... more of these sorts of teachings please!). The offerings from

COMMUNICATION & TRANSPARENCY EFFORTS

3 / 28 responses — new & returning

A smaller theme in this question, but notable because communication recurs as the dominant improvement area in later responses. Where it works, staff notice and appreciate it.

NEW "It strives to maintain effective communication through various channels, for example 'The Hollyhock Sun - News For You' which I enjoy reading every week. It cares for employees to express their concerns and suggestions, creating opportunities to express them."

RET "Communicating more (ex: The Sun) about campus operations, programming really amazing presenters, caring for the staff experience as much

elders are so important."

RET "Supportive work environment where people's unique qualities are celebrated and welcome ... deepening relationships with indigenous groups and the land, gratitude practices, meaningful work."

as the participant experience."

RET "Reaching out to Community and diversifying guests and staff."

What is something Hollyhock as an organisation could improve on?

Responses here were candid and often specific. Communication failures, training gaps, and workload pressure emerged as the clearest organizational signals — and notably, new staff named the same problems as returning staff on arrival, before accumulated context would explain the frustration. A small number of responses raise concerns that are lower frequency but higher stakes: conflict left unresolved, compensation inequity, and one detailed account of kitchen hygiene that warrants direct follow-up regardless of how many people raised it.

COMMUNICATION & INTERDEPARTMENTAL COORDINATION

9 / 28 responses — new & returning

The single most common improvement theme. Returning staff describe it as a systemic cost in time, money, and institutional memory. New staff arrive and notice the gaps immediately, strengthening this signal considerably.

NEW "Communication between Supervisor/Manager/Depa General inspection of equipment and working procedures."

NEW "Cross team communication could be improved, as well as direct communication of what is needed and expected. This could be by making the all-team weekly meeting a time to share big current projects and deadlines, and provide an opportunity for teams to identify

TRAINING, ONBOARDING & PROCEDURE DOCUMENTATION

6 / 28 responses — new & returning

New staff are notably more direct about onboarding gaps; returning staff frame it as professional development. Together they identify both ends of the training pipeline. Procedure manuals are called out specifically.

NEW "Better quality and longer onboarding training. Update/creation of procedure manuals for each position. Complimentary meals while on shift or the option of a staff meal plan."

NEW "It could be good to find out the strengths and interests of the employees to see if they might be able to contribute in better ways, even in a volunteer capacity alongside the jobs they've been hired for. I believe most people drawn to

STAFF CONSULTATION & COLLABORATIVE DECISION-MAKING

4 / 28 responses — returning only

All four responses came from returning staff, who have enough context to recognize when decisions are made without their input. The concern is not about the decisions themselves but about being consulted before, not informed after.

RET "Collaborative decision making."

RET "When making changes I think it is essential that staff are consulted and actually listened to, no one person has all the information. Especially the staff who will have to carry out the work to implement the change or deal with the outcomes of the change."

RET "For persons in leadership positions to better understand the culture that goes on

areas of crossover or head off potential issues before they arise."

RET "COMMUNICATION!!! So much inefficiency, time and money wasted due to ineffective or non-communication between depts, silo-ing or lost organizational knowledge when people leave as there's often little or no training manuals made before their departure."

RET "Email culture."

RET "Clarity and communication of our mission."

RET "I feel that we could improve on interdepartmental systems and processes — and subsequently a little bit of that is communication. That said, I think we're already working on this."

RET "Focusing on practicality and realistic goals, listening to department needs, and campus-life experience."

Hollyhock are life-long learners who have much to offer."

RET "Providing better support and training to staff."

RET "Better training for new staff."

RET "Staff training in order to grow — individual, professional and as a whole."

RET "I think Hollyhock could improve on offering professional development that can help staff grow and develop their skills and strengths and expand their skills and professionally develop in new ways."

in each department — the challenges they face and what key players would wish to see insofar as change."

RET "Focusing on practicality and realistic goals, listening to department needs, and campus-life experience. Not hiring out of desperation, better background checks and more respectful and considerate decisions around staff housing."

RET "For persons in leadership positions to better understand the culture that goes on in each department — the challenges they face and what key players would wish to see insofar as change."

RET "Collaborative decision making."

WORKLOAD, BURNOUT & HUSTLE CULTURE

4 / 28 responses — new & returning

Returning staff describe burnout as a structural cycle; new staff name the culture directly. The new staff framing ("hustle/urgency culture") is the explicit label for what returning staff describe in behavioral terms.

NEW "Hustle/urgency culture, overwork, new processes and systems to improve workflow, reduce number of meetings, encourage staff to take lieu time, block calendars, etc."

RET "Summer will always be a busy season but resources can feel delicate — as soon as someone is sick or unwell, it throws off the balance and mental states can decline quickly. When other depts have to 'pick up the work,' it begins to add load and during the busy season, it's hard to actually use up the

WAGES & COMPENSATION EQUITY

4 / 28 responses — new & returning

Despite Q1 praise for the wage increase, some respondents still raise wage concerns. Returning staff focus on internal equity; new staff raise absolute wage levels.

NEW "It seems like there is always budget concerns. It would take a big re-structuring, but I'm curious what could be done to support better wages for employees and also sustain the organization. The low wage was my only concern this season. Otherwise, I had a great season."

RET "Pay the bodyworkers reasonably."

RET "Wage ratio."

RET "There's no wage transparency into SLT and upper management wages."

CONFLICT RESOLUTION & STAFF HOUSING

2 / 28 responses — returning only

Two returning staff raise conflict as inadequately resolved this season. Housing is named as a compounding factor, since problematic co-workers are also co-habitants.

RET "Helping people understand one another. Many conflicts this year went unsatisfactorily unresolved, some were despicable."

RET "The problem with retaining employees who don't work well and aren't respectful to live with is that wholesome professionals will not want to come back if it means that they have to live with chaotic people. I think clear protocols need to be put into practice in order to assure the quick outflow of inadequate workers/roommates."

lieu time so we get into wellness debt. Once the season is over, the burnout is SO real that the recovery time cuts into next year's planning, and cascades into already feeling 'behind'."

RET "Long term planning."

RET "I think ES has been making improvements over the years but I think our Core presenters could be even more streamlined with standard ES operating procedures, expectations, and prep."

NOTED, NOT RECURRING

24/7 STAFFING COVERAGE — NEW STAFF

"I think it would be good if there would be at least one staff member around 24/7 when guests are in, so that whatever situation occurs, there is someone in person to speak to."

INTERNSHIP & HIRING PRACTICES — RETURNING STAFF

"I've noticed a growing emphasis on adopting certain American internship practices, which seem to prioritize candidates from privileged or elite educational backgrounds. This approach can feel more like a branding exercise than one grounded in our core values. I believe the organisation could explore more inclusive and locally grounded pathways for bringing in new talent — ones that focus on genuine alignment with our mission rather than prestige."

FOOD SAFETY & KITCHEN SANITATION — RETURNING STAFF

"Please improve sanitation and cleanliness standards in the kitchen. It's beyond unsanitary, with almost all cooks fully licking the stirring/serving spoons while cooking, then right back into the pots, even when they're sick. Licking fingers or full hands and then tossing salads with said unwashed hands. Dropping things on the floor and continuing to chop them. There seems to be zero cleanliness training. Also please get sneeze guards for the buffet and some kind of cleanliness protocols in place."

What does "organizational transparency" in a workplace mean for you?

Staff across both groups define transparency primarily as clear, timely communication about decisions and the reasoning behind them. Returning staff extend that definition further, adding psychological safety and protected feedback channels as essential components. New staff are more likely to frame it in operational terms — knowing their role, having access to organizational information. Where the groups converge, the definition is consistent: transparency means being brought into the "why," not just the "what."

OPEN, TIMELY COMMUNICATION ABOUT DECISIONS

12 / 24 responses — new & returning

The dominant definition. Staff understand transparency as leadership communicating clearly about decisions, especially those that affect staff themselves, with enough context to understand the reasoning, not just the outcome.

NEW "When an organization is open and honest about the company's goals, mission, vision, strategy, financials, challenges, etc. with all partners, including staff — and where everyone is accountable for their actions, trust is built, and communication is prioritized."

NEW "Openly sharing information with employees, such as decisions, processes and performance."

PSYCHOLOGICAL SAFETY TO SPEAK UP

5 / 24 responses — returning only

All responses came from returning staff. Transparency is not just top-down information flow but requires conditions where staff can raise concerns and give feedback without fear of penalty. This connects directly to the empowerment gap noted above.

RET "Being able to openly dialogue challenging or vulnerable topics without fear of being penalized or dismissed."

RET "Honest and open communication, room for questions and feedback."

RET "The SLT and Board are willing to communicate openly with staff about strategic plans, organizational changes, goals, intentions, and changes to process. I think it also means

WAGE & FINANCIAL TRANSPARENCY

3 / 24 responses — new & returning

Both new and returning staff name financial and wage transparency as part of their definition. New staff frame it broadly; returning staff are more specific about SLT compensation and campus/remote wage bands.

NEW "Wage transparency. Equal opportunity to new and open positions both internally and publicly. Equal opportunity to perks. Managerial decisions, policy changes, budget allocations shared within the organization and accessible to all."

RET "SLT and upper management wage transparency for all staff. Remote and campus wage bands and how and why they differ. Transparency when making large decisions that will affect the whole

NEW "Hmm. I'd imagine just being clear on the goals of the organization and of the roles within it."

NEW "openness and honesty with the management details and structure of the organization."

NEW "To me, this means being open with the organizations aims, challenges, and plans."

RET "It means that decisions are made with appropriate levels of consultation, and that people impacted are informed in a timely manner and also in an effective way so they actually receive the information that allows them to understand how their leadership operates."

RET "Staff understand what the organisation is doing and why and feel confident to support organisational decision making and direction in the community."

RET "To have senior managers and executives be that there is an open channel for feedback where staff can communicate without fear of being penalized. And that their privacy around such feedback is respected and protected."

RET "The ability to communicate openly when things are going well, but also in challenging situations — things that are unfortunately lacking, because management is operating out of fear and scarcity, and this vibration trickles down to everyone."

RET "Things are open where possible."

organization and everyone's jobs."

RET "There's no wage transparency into SLT and upper management wages."

completely open and honest with staff members."

RET "Clear and timely communication around decisions that affect onsite staff and the campus."

RET "Sharing facts rather than smooth talking."

RET "Clear communication."

RET "Understanding how and why decisions are made."

ROLE & PROCESS CLARITY

3 / 24 responses — new staff only

A theme contributed entirely by new staff, who define transparency partly as knowing what their role requires and how things work, a more operational lens than the governance-focused definitions from returning staff.

NEW "That the roles, tasks and responsibilities are clear."

NEW "Hmm. I'd imagine just being clear on the goals of the organization and of the roles within it."

NEW "When something should be confidential it should stay confidential so people don't start gossiping."

NOTED, NOT RECURRING

CALIBRATED OPENNESS — RETURNING STAFF

"The staff are brought into the loop when it comes to change, planning, and direction. It sounds strange, but some transparency is good, too much can cause concern or be ineffective."

ORGANIZATIONAL STANDING — RETURNING STAFF

"That everyone is on the level with how the organisation is doing, what it is claiming to stand for and what it intends to become."

CROSS-QUESTION SYNTHESIS

Signals Across the Dataset

REQUIRES FOLLOW-UP

Food safety concern

One Q2 response contains detailed, specific allegations about kitchen hygiene practices. This is a single respondent and should not be treated as a widespread complaint. However, the specificity, urgency, and health/liability implications mean it should be investigated directly. It cannot be averaged away by its frequency in the data.

CULTURE

Burnout is structural; hustle culture is its name

The quantitative data shows a 25-point gap in workload concerns between new and returning staff. The Q2 open text explains the mechanism: a seasonal cycle where burnout recovery eats into next-season planning. A new staff respondent names this directly as hustle/urgency culture and offers concrete countermeasures. The two framings together make a stronger case for structural intervention than either would alone.

CULTURE

Returning staff apply a more critical lens to transparency

In Q3, new staff define transparency in terms of role and process clarity. Returning staff include that, but extend it to psychological safety and the ability to give feedback without fear. The most pointed response in the dataset came from a returning staff member. This is consistent with empowerment scores not improving with tenure in the quantitative data.

STRUCTURAL

Communication is the central organizational concern

Communication problems surface in every question and from both new and returning staff. In Q1 it appears as a strength (the Hollyhock Sun, feedback channels). In Q2 it is the most common improvement theme (9/28 responses). In Q3, transparent and timely communication is the dominant definition of what organizational transparency even means. The new/returning convergence rules out a tenure-specific frustration.

STRUCTURAL

New staff name the same problems as returning staff, but faster

New staff are not yet habituated to the organization friction points, so their observations are fresh and unfiltered. They independently flag communication gaps, onboarding inadequacy, and hustle culture, the same structural concerns that returning staff describe with years of accumulated context. When both groups arrive at the same diagnosis from different vantage points, the signal is robust.

STRUCTURAL

Onboarding is a specific and actionable gap

New staff are considerably more direct about onboarding than returning staff, who frame the issue as professional development. New staff specifically name: longer onboarding duration, procedure manuals by role, and better use of existing staff skills and knowledge. These are discrete, implementable asks rather than general sentiment.

STRUCTURAL

Wage progress is recognized, but equity and transparency gaps remain

The 2025 wage increase drew spontaneous praise from six respondents in Q1, from both new and returning staff. Yet Q2 and Q3 both surface wage concerns: bodyworker pay, remote vs. campus wage bands, SLT salary visibility, and for new staff, absolute wage levels. Leadership should not read Q1 praise as full closure. The appreciation and the concern coexist in the same dataset.

Appendix — Survey Responses

CUSTOM RESPONSES — MULTI-SELECT QUESTIONS

Why did you join, return to, or stay at Hollyhock? — write-in responses

- Space away from city-living for study
- Amazing food
- Part of my "retirement" plan, i.e. contributing and giving back to a place i love and which has given me much in past decades.
- I love how inviting everyone is.
- I came for the location and fell in love with it for so many reasons. I felt cared for and appreciated.
- Team and culture
- Food

What types of training opportunities would you like to see next year? — write-in responses

- Anything related to maintenance
- Kitchen Skills Training for Kitchen Staff Before Season Start
- Expanding opportunities
- All great options! I'm open to any and all

What's a particularly rewarding and/or motivating part of working at Hollyhock? — write-in responses

- Hot tub!
- Responses from guests
- It's one place I feel at peace in a chaotic and often angry world.
- Working within a team that is dedicated to upholding a high standard of staff experience, Working within a team that strives to offer quality work atmosphere and competitive wages for local Cortesians.

What is a particularly challenging part of working at Hollyhock? — write-in responses

- lack of health benefits (health spending account only goes so far), lack of operational leadership on campus (especially, but not exclusively, as it relates to interdepartmental communication)
- to be surrounded by so many different and always changing people all the time, but i like it though:)
- Driving all the way from whaletown everyday
- Seeing colleagues burn out
- Stressed Manager
- Physically it would be a challenge to continue for years in the position I was in.
- Wage inequality between local staff and remote staff.
- None
- High energy, different people coming every week
- scary spiders

What is your favourite perk at Hollyhock? — write-in responses

- Complimentary program
- Breakfast, and complimentary program second :)
- Magic meals fridge
- Would be nice if the kitchen was making more food to have lunch and dinner sometimes cause lot of peole jump in without asking and then there is nothing left even for guest chefs are too greedy they cook only for the exact amounth of guest and themself they dont think of the staff staff shouls be served first
- I cant pick one
- Both breakfast and magic fridge
- Breakfast
- driving down the hill on a sunny day
- Comp program AND having a place to stay at/near campus for remote staff, without having to pay out of pocket
- As a remote worker I really appreciate being able to come to campus for the comp program, but also to receive a discount on accommodation and meals so that I can come and visit. I also really appreciate having access to accommodation that is not taking away from paying guests.

- All! The food probably first but having access to presenter evenings is wonderful too.
- All of the above! :) But it would also be really helpful to have full health benefits!

Which team-building activities would you be interested in? — write-in responses

- i appriciate alot intimit sharing circles, giving space to each one to speak and be heard. it can create very deep feeling of connectedness and trust in a group, depending of how its initiated.
- I will not be coming back next season, so this question is not relevant.
- I'd be happy to take part in any. I love the learning nights. I'd also love to see what I suggested (learning from each other)
- Activities that can include all staff without excluding those that are on shift when the staff activity is scheduled.
- Professsional development learnings, fieldtrips etc...
- More opportunities for offsite staff to connect

OPEN-ENDED QUESTION RESPONSES — ALL RESPONDENTS

What is something Hollyhock, as an organisation, is doing well?

- Wage lift was awesome
- Increased wages
- Job elements are good. Laundry is done well, food is good, etc.
- giving alot of trust to the guests, what creates a feeling of home
- Deep care for employees and guests. Management really tries to uphold the mission statement of HH and they do a lovely job - The heart and soul of Hollyhock campus management is lovely. Wonderful people, spirit and intention.
- Investing in staff experience
- Strong work ethic and work ambiance setting
- Generally providing guests with a positive and enriching experience.
- Creating a positive work environment
- Getting better at supporting onsite staff

- Reaching out to Community and diversifying guests and staff
- Always finding a solution fast and being caring.
- great food
- Better wages, trying to pay more attention to staff experience and staff needs
- Delivering powerful experiences for guests
- the food has been great this year
- Carrying for others. Offering an enriched environment.
- Working on improving campus staff experience. There has been a positive shift in valuing campus staff with wage increases and more onsite perks. This goes a long way and translates into a higher quality guest experience. Moving in this direction will hopefully increase staff retention and seasonal return staff.
- Communicating more (ex: The Sun) about campus operations, programming really amazing presenters, caring for the staff experience as much as the participant experience.
- Supportive work environment where people's unique qualities are celebrated and welcome (attracts great human beings), growth opportunities for staff and guests, so many perks, staff enrichment and connection opportunities are always warm and fun, staff retention: people come back year after year because it's a great company to work for, deepening relationships with indigenous groups and the land, gratitude practices, meaningful work, etc. I feel that Hollyhock is doing a lot of things well.
- I think Hollyhock is doing well at trying to support a wide range of staff with a wide array of skills and needs.
- Guest experience, team culture of helping and supporting each other
- It promotes a safe and healthy work environment. It strives to maintain effective communication within the organization through various channels, for example "The Hollyhock Sun - News For You" which I enjoy reading every week. It cares for employees to express their concerns and suggestions, creating opportunities to express them. And of course, all the amazing perks we have!
- We have such a great staff cohort and all of the perks are wonderful. The garden and the restaurant are such beautiful connecting places. The wage raise was also greatly appreciated this year. The mission to create a vibrant and healthy community at Hollyhock that extends out into the larger world is meaningful and inspiring. The land stewardship and teachings about this specific place we live are also deeply appreciated. (Bill's nature walks and bird walks...Brenda and

Rose...more of these sorts of teachings please!). The offerings from elders are so important.

- healthy yummy food
- Acknowledging staff importance by raising wadges.
- Staff community
- Hollyhock is a incredibly inclusive workplace, that puts employee welfare high on the agenda.

What is something Hollyhock as an organisation could improve on?

- Collaborative decision making
- When making changes I think it is essential that staff are consulted and actually listened to, no one person has all the information. Especially the staff who will have to carry out the work to implement the change or deal with the outcomes of the change.
- Helping people understand one another. Many conflicts this year went unsatisfactorily unresolved, some were despicable.
- i think it would be good if there would be at least one stuff member arround 24/7 when guests are in. so that what ever situation occures, there is someone in person to speak to.
- It seems like there is always budget concerns. It would take a big re-structuring, but I'm curious what could be done to support better wages for employees and also sustain the organization. The low wage was my only concern this season. Otherwise, I had a great season.
- Long term planning
- Comunication between Supervisor/ Manager / Departement. General inspection of equipement and working procedures
- Providing better support and training to staff.
- Pay the bodyworkers reasonably
- Wage ratio
- Staff training in order.to grow, individual, professional and as a whole
- Better training for new staff .
- transparency, dealing with conflict

- Focusing on practicality and realistic goals, Listening to department needs, and campus-life experience. Not hiring out of desperation, better background checks and more respectful and considerate decisions around staff housing.
- Clarity and communication of our mission
- email culture
- It could be good to find out the strengths and interests of the employees to see if they might be able to contribute in better ways, even in a volunteer capacity alongside the jobs they've been hired for. I saw that many of the employees have skills that weren't utilized and could benefit Hollyhock. (could be fun for the employees who want to to put on a teaching night (can't remember what they are called) so we can learn from each other, as I believe most people drawn to Hollyhock are life-long learners who have much to offer.)
- Better quality and longer onboarding training. Update/creation of procedure manuals for each position. Complimentary meals while on shift or the option of staff meal plan.
- Summer will always be a busy season but resources can feel delicate that as soon as someone is sick or unwell, it throws off the balance and all of the sudden, mental states can decline quickly. When other depts have to "pick up the work," it begins to add load and during the busy season, it's hard to actually use up the lieu time so we get into wellness debt. Once the season is over, the burnout is SO real that the recovery time cuts into next year's planning, and cascades into already feeling "behind". I think ES has been making improvements over the years but I think our Core presenters could be even more streamlined with standard ES operating procedures, expectations, and prep. Thinking about other retreat centers, their ES departments seem very clear on what they can/cannot offer and any associated $$ fees for extra work done.
- I'm sure many folks would put "wage" here but I actually feel that we have the highest wages on this island. Instead, I feel that we could improve on interdepartmental systems and processes - and subsequently a little bit of that is communication. That said, I think we're already working on this
- I think Hollyhock could improve on offering professional development that can help staff grow and develop their skills and strengths and expand their skills and professionally develop in new ways.
- Hustle/urgency culture, overwork, new processes and systems to improve workflow, reduce number of meetings, encourage staff to take lieu time, block calendars, etc.
- There's nothing a can think of right now.

- I’ve noticed a growing emphasis on adopting certain American internship practices, which seem to prioritize candidates from privileged or elite educational backgrounds. This approach can feel more like a branding exercise than one grounded in our core values. I believe the organisation could explore more inclusive and locally grounded pathways for bringing in new talent—ones that focus on genuine alignment with our mission rather than prestige. I think it’s worth reflecting on how to stay authentic and values-driven as we grow. But also to be clear here, I am very much appreciating Katia's presence on campus and even more so that she has moved here and is making Cortes her home and efforts to be part of this community. I am not anti-American but I do question this internship practice we are adapting.
- keeping bugs out of the rooms
- For persons in leadership positions to better understand the culture that goes on in each department - the challenges they face and what key players would wish to see insofar as change. Also, more staff housing opportunities. Concerning staffing, I know that it is always a dance between hiring good workers and actually having anyone to hire at all. The problem with retaining employees who don't work well and aren't respectful to live with is that wholesome professionals will not want to come back if it means that they have to live with chaotic people. I think clear protocols need to be put into practice in order to assure the quick outflow of inadequate workers/roommates.
- COMMUNICATION!!!!!!!!!!!!!!! Sooo much inefficiency, time and money wasted due to ineffective or non-communcation between depts, silo-ing or lost organizational knowledge when people leave as there's often liitle or no training manuals made before their departure. There's no wage transparency into SLT and upper management wages. Also PLEASE, PLEASE PLEASE improve sanitation and cleanliness standards in the kitchen!!! It's beyond unsanitary, with almost all cooks fully licking the stiring/serving spoons while cooking, then right back into the pots, even when they're sick. Licking fingers or full hands and then tossing salads etc with said unwashed hands. Dropping things on the floor and continuing to chop them. There seems to be zero cleanliness training! It's the worst I've ever seen! I've witnessed some horrifying things in the kitchen this year. Soooooo GROSS!!! Also PLEASE get sneeze guards for the buffett and some kind of cleanliness protocols in place! Many guests will taste things with the general serving spoons and put back into the communal dish. Some signs might help and perhaps having a fresh plate rule for getting seconds. As things are the cleanliness is incredibly bad!
- Cross team communication could be improved, as well as direct communication of what is needed and expected. This could be by making the all team weekly

meeting a time to share big current projects and deadlines, and provide an opportunity for teams to identify areas of crossover or head off potential issues before they arise.

What does "organizational transparency" in a workplace mean for you?

- It means that decisions are made with appropriate levels of consultation, and that people impacted are informed in a timely manner and also in an effective way so they actually receive the information that allows them to understand how their leadership operates
- that the roles, tasks and responsabilities are clear
- openness and honesty with the management details and structure of the organization.
- Staff understand what the organisation is doing and why and feel confident to support organisational decision making and direction in the community
- When something should be (confidential) it should stay confidential so peopele don't start gossiping.
- To have senior managers and executives be completely open and honest with staff members.
- Clear and timely Communication around decisions that affect onsite staff and the campus.
- Sharing facts rather than smooth talking
- Clear communication
- the ability to communicate openly when things are going well, but also in challenging situations things that are unfortunately lacking, because management is operating out of fear and scarcity, and this vibration trickles down to everyone
- Honest and open communication, room for questions and feedback.
- Understanding how and why decisions are made
- things are open where possible
- Hmm. I'd imagine just being clear on the goals of the organization and of the roles within it.
- Wage transparency. Equal opportunity to new and open positions both internally and publicly. Equal opportunity to perks. Managerial decisions, policy changes, budget allocations shared within the organization and accessible to all.

- Being able to openly dialogue challenging or vulnerable topics without fear of being penalized or dismissed.
- The staff are brought into the loop when it comes to change, planning, and direction. It sounds strange, but some transparency is good, too much can cause concern or be ineffective.
- organizational transparency in a workplace, for me, means that the SLT and Board are willing to communicate openly with staff about strategic plans, organizational changes, goals, intentions, and changes to process or changes that impact the nature of the work we are doing. I think it also means that there is an open channel for feedback where staff can communicate without fear of being penalized. And that their privacy around such feedback is respected and protected.
- When an organization is open and honest about the company's goals, mission, vision, strategy, financials, challenges, etc. with all partners, including staff and where everyone is accountable for their actions, trust is built, and communication is prioritized
- Openly sharing information with employees, such as decisions, processes and performance.
- not sure
- That everyone is on the level with how the organisation is doing, what it is claiming to stand for and what it intends to become.
- SLT and upper management wage transparency for all staff. Remote and Campus wage bands and how and why they differ. Transparency when making large decision that will effect the whole organization and everyone's jobs.
- To me, this means being open with the organizations aims, challenges, and plans.